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PRESENTATION

OF THE

ROYAL PREMIUM

AWARDED TO DR. GEO. A. WALLIN OF FINLAND, AND TO MR. THOMAS BRUNNER OF NEW ZEALAND.

The Annual Report of the Council having been read, the President addressed the Meeting as follows:—

GENTLEMEN,—We have acted again upon the principle followed last year in the case of the Rev. David Livingston, of distributing in *money* the amount of the Royal Grant entrusted to us for the "Encouragement of Geographical Science and Discovery," to those travellers who, in the opinion of your Council, have established for themselves strong claims to participate in the fund in question, when no case has arisen of sufficient importance to justify the award of the highest honour at the disposal of the Society. The Council has this year divided the sum of 50 guineas equally between Dr. George Augustus Wallin, of Helsingfors in Finland, and Mr. Thomas Brunner, an explorer of New Zealand; and, although the results of the labours of both these gentlemen are printed in the last Number of your Journal, the duty devolves upon me to show you the grounds of this decision.

Dr. Wallin has traversed a large portion of the Peninsula of Arabia hitherto untrodden by Europeans, and has collected in the course of his travels a large amount of geographical information of very great interest, which he has communicated to the Society. This founds the claim for the Council's award; but I may state the successive steps by which this energetic traveller succeeded in almost identifying himself with the Arabs of the Desert.

Having studied the Eastern languages in his native town, he obtained a pension from his Government, with permission to travel in the Levant. At Alexandria he formed an acquaintance with a learned sheïkh, whom he accompanied to Caïro, and by whom he was introduced to some Bedowin Arabs. With them he, for a considerable time, took up his abode, and soon became so fond of this mode of living, that—like our countryman, the intrepid and greatly re-

gretted Browne—he was tempted to think the simple, inartificial manners of those Children of the Desert preferable to the conventional and sometimes inconvenient refinements of European society. In December, 1846, after passing eight months in Caïro on returning from his first excursion among the Arabs, he hired some camels, and set out with a party of Bedowins for the peninsula of Mount Sinai, the Gulf of 'Aḳabah, Kebron, Jerusalem, and across the great Syrian Desert. Near the end of 1847, in the company of a party of Arabs, he visited Túr, hard by the southern extremity of the Arabian Peninsula, and afterwards performed the long and arduous journey to Háïl, almost in the heart of the Peninsula. From thence he proceeded northwards to the well-known shrine of 'Alí, about 30 miles west of the Euphrates, which he reached on the 15th of May, 1848.

On arriving at Baghdád, the traveller found that the French merchant, on whom he had letters of credit, was dead; he therefore, having nearly exhausted his funds, set off for Tehrán, where he received a fresh supply from the Russian agent. On his return to the southward, he was compelled by local circumstances to make himself known to Captain Jones, of the Indian Navy, and was by him introduced to Colonel Rawlinson, her Majesty's Consul at Baghdád. The Colonel has acquainted me of his soon finding that, in addition to his extraordinary aptitude for acquiring the Eastern manners and languages, Dr. Wallin possesses no common intimacy with the literal Arabic and many of the best Arab writers.

Struck with the fact that a better acquaintance with the interior of Arabia is still an urgent desideratum, and that in him we had a qualified organ, in respect to age, health, and abilities, your Council empowered me to treat with Dr. Wallin; but the probable expense being beyond our means, Sir Roderick Murchison, at my request, addressed the Grand Duke Constantine, as President of the Imperial Geographical Society of St. Petersburg, expressing a hope of assistance in the undertaking. To this application we have not yet received a reply. Her Majesty's Government and the East India Company have placed the sum of 200*l.* at our disposal, which we are very desirous of devoting to this purpose, together with a loan of proper instruments.

Your second award, Gentlemen, is to Mr. Thomas Brunner, whose expedition to explore the Middle Island of New Zealand was pointedly alluded to in my last Address. His journey through a rugged and wild country was attended with great fatigue and danger; and his narrative of no less than 550 days of exertion is a plain, straightforward statement of what an adventurous man has seen and felt. His resources were very slender, his personal privations exceedingly severe, and his perseverance throughout so long a toil most meritorious.

During this arduous journey, Mr. Brunner obtained an accurate knowledge of about 200 miles of the coast, from Cape Foul-wind to Titihaia Headland. He examined a considerable portion of the interior, and satisfied himself of the barren and unprofitable character of

that part of the island; he traced the courses of several rivers, and discovered more than one extensive lake; and he has proved that that portion of the western side of Middle Island is unsuitable for colonization. While travelling, all his party fared alike, and each carried his own baggage; but through all the toils thus encountered—and it is worth particularly noting—he never had occasion to fear the natives, who already are all Wesleyans, and, as far as their poor means went, behaved as Christians.

Such are the grounds on which your Council have awarded the other portion of the Royal donation to Mr. Thomas Brunner.